

with good luck. Perhaps the meaning of this strange act was to drive out harmful spirits believed to be tangled in the bride's hair. Customs such as this show how fascinating gladiators were to ordinary Roman people.

Feared fighters

The truth is, underneath this fascination with gladiators lay a tremendous fear of them.

It was because gladiators were professional fighters, trained in the brutal art of committing public executions, that they scared most Romans.

Despite this, the Romans loved watching these powerful fighters battle it out in the arena from the safety of their ringside seats. Children played with pottery gladiator dolls, and people had pictures of them in their homes—on

THE LAST GLADIATOR CONTESTS TOOK PLACE MORE THAN 1,600 YEARS AGO.



lamps, tableware, and mosaics. These often showed real fights, with the names of the gladiators written beside them. We know from the writings of Pliny the Elder that gladiators were a popular subject in Roman art for many generations.

THIS IS A TOMBSTONE OF A RETIARIUS—A GLADIATOR WHO FOUGHT WITH A NET AND A THREE-PRONGED SPEAR CALLED A TRIDENT.